

Q.2a (15 marks): What are the defining characteristics of a scientific discipline, and does Anthropology meet those criteria?

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As per Vaid, Oriental Anthropology (2021),
 Anthropology is the holistic study of
socio-cultural and biological evolution
and variation in a human across
space and time.

It is an important discipline with
 its roots in many social sciences like
 Sociology, Psychology, History, Economics,
 Political Science as well as scientific
disciplines like Geology, Earth Sciences,
Life Sciences (Biology, Zoology, Anatomy)
and Medical Sciences.

Understanding major features of a

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Scientific discipline →

- ↳ Based on rational logics and not any superstition or subjective beliefs
- ↳ Objective analysis of phenomena
- ↳ Establishment of cause and effect relationship
- ↳ Deriving universal laws and formulas based on observation and hypothesis
- ↳ Testing the laws and applying them in a real life situation for deriving utility for humanity and world

Anthropology Similar to Scientific Features

- ↳ Using etic approach, several anthropologists have analysed phenomena objectively
eg: Cultural materialists have analysed Potlatch ceremony of Kwakiwut as safety value for malnutrition

- Cause and effect relationships have been established eg. Alliance theory states that alliances via marriages have the reason of preventing wars
- eg. Biocultural adaptations to extreme climate like PEPSE gene in Tibetans.
- Universal laws → Development of hybrid bone led to voice development
- eg. Erect posture of man led to narrowing of birth canal and hence led to need of social bonding and family.

However

- Etic approach - leads to subjective interpretation of phenomena each time eg. Historical Particularism
- Diverse cultural practices have subjective reasons with varying cultural constructs
- Difficult to generalise universal law eg. Edmund Leach says even though Kathleen Gough's definition of marriage is widest, it is not universal.

Thus, anthropology's beauty lies in its diversity and not scientific generalisation